

Picture Perfect

Photoshop



Or is it? Here's a close look at some of the new features and enhancements in Photoshop 7

Photoshop was launched 12 years ago and over the years it has been constantly upgraded to suit people's needs. The first version that shipped in 1990 had a full palette of tools for creating images from scratch, as well as for editing, altering and enhancing images. With Photoshop 2.0 came features meant for black-and-white image editing and pre-press colour-separation tasks. Photoshop 3 saw the introduction of layers and new

colour-correction tools. Further enhancements such as watermarking, layer adjustments, and actions that streamlined your work were seen in its next release. Photoshop 5 and 5.5 introduced 'Undo' capabilities, 'History' palette, 'Vertical Text', 'Magnetic Lasso' tool and an all-new image editing package, 'Image Ready', for creating animations. Photoshop 6 was a killer app of sorts with features such as integrated vector drawing tools, new dockable

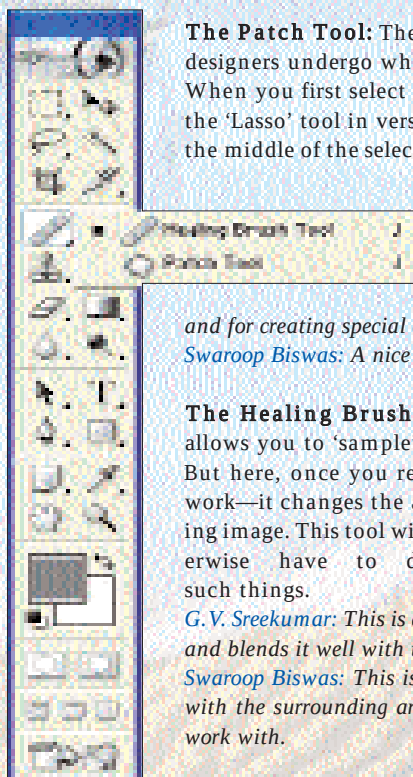
toolbar, text warping and enhanced layer management.

So what exactly does Adobe have in store for you with the release of Photoshop 7? We tested the software and also asked for expert opinions from G.V. Sreekumar, Faculty Member, Industrial Design Centre, IIT-Powai, and Swaroop Biswas, Manager-Design, Jasubhai Digital Media. Let's take a peek at the all-new Photoshop 7 and explore its worthiness.

Toolbar: The first thing you notice when you open Photoshop 7 is the elegant toolbar. It is similar to the one in Photoshop 6 but the palette and icons now have a 3D look. Each tool icon generates colour when you hover your mouse over it. As for the tool palette, nothing much has changed except that the 'Air brush' tool has now been accommodated into the 'Paint brush' tool option. The 'Text' tool has a few extra choices that were a part of the extra toolbar in the previous version. Similarly, the 'Slice' tool options have been revamped and are no longer available in the dockable extra toolbar that rests right below the menu.

G.V. Sreekumar: The 3D look doesn't add any value. The old toolbar, which looks crisp and clear, was better.

Swaroop Biswas: Though there are 3D icons, they don't make much of a difference to a designer. Moreover, they make the program a bit heavy.



The Patch Tool: The inclusion of this tool will reduce some of the trouble that designers undergo when trying to achieve accuracy while manipulating images. When you first select this tool, it gives you a lasso cursor, which works just like the 'Lasso' tool in version 6. However, after making a selection, you can click in the middle of the selected area and then drag it to a new location. Photoshop then blends this dragged information into the underlying image in an attempt to blend in the brightness, colour and texture of the surrounding information. This tool makes for effortless manipulation of images.

G.V. Sreekumar: Useful while restoring damaged photographs and for creating special effects. Results can be very dramatic.

Swaroop Biswas: A nice addition, but it is a feature that is not often used.

The Healing Brush: The 'Healing brush', similar to the 'Rubber Stamp' tool, allows you to 'sample' from one area of an image and apply it somewhere else. But here, once you release the mouse button, Photoshop does the rest of the work—it changes the area you retouched so as to blend it in with the surrounding image. This tool will be well appreciated by the digital imagist who would otherwise have to devote copious amounts of time in perfecting such things.

G.V. Sreekumar: This is a useful tool. It intelligently retouches the area around the image and blends it well with the surroundings. Useful for beginners.

Swaroop Biswas: This is a nice addition. It not only clones the area but also merges it with the surrounding area and makes one's work much simpler. However, it's slow to work with.

File Browser: Earlier, browsing for new images while working in Photoshop was rather inconvenient. But the new File Browser lets you search and view images while working in Photoshop itself. Viewing images from the File Browser provides Metadata about images displayed such as the date on which it was created/modified, and also Exchangeable Image File (EXIF) information from digital cameras. You can rotate, batch rename, rank and sort your images from the File Browser.